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**FRESH FLIGHT** PM Narendra Modi with Tata chairman N. Chandrasekaran and Airbus chief commercial officer Christian Scherer at the foundation-laying ceremony of the C-295 plant in Vadodara, Oct. 30

TATA-AIRBUS PROJECT

# EARNING OUR WINGS

By Pradip R. Sagar

Ever since it emerged that India had signed a deal in September 2021 with Airbus Defence and Space, SA, Spain, to procure and manufacture 56 C-295 medium-weight transport aircraft for the Indian Air Force, speculation was rife about the location of its plant in India. With Prime Minister Narendra Modi laying the foundation stone of the manufacturing unit in Vadodara, in poll-bound Gujarat, on October 30, that matter has been put to rest. Defence secretary Dr Ajay Kumar said that as part of the contract, 16 aircraft will be delivered in flyaway condition and 40 will be manufactured in India through a joint venture between Airbus and the Indian aircraft contractor, Tata Advanced Systems Limited (TASL) and Tata Consultancy Services (TCS), led by TASL. The total cost of the project is Rs 21,935 crore. Significantly, this is the first time that a military aircraft will be manufactured in India by a private company.

Indeed, the 'private' element in the Tata-Airbus joint venture is being considered a watershed moment: many share PM Modi's hope that this will open the floodgates for aircraft manufacturing in India, where Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL), the state-owned aerospace and defence company headquartered in Bengaluru, has had a complete dominance. Highlighting the